

Social Media

Zach Dickson & Dan de Kadt

London School of Economics

WT 2025

Social media platforms for research



1 Introduction to Social Media Data

- Benefits & Limitations of Social Media Data

2 Types of Social Media Data and APIs

- Reddit
- Twitter/X
- Facebook & Instagram
- TikTok

3 Summary

What is Social Media Data?

- Data generated by users on social media platforms

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Forms of Social Media Data

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- **Engagement**: likes, shares, comments, etc.

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Article | [Open access](#) | Published: 02 February 2021

No echo in the chambers of political interactions on Reddit

[Gianmarco De Francisci Morales](#) ✉, [Corrado Monti](#) ✉ & [Michele Starnini](#) ✉

[Scientific Reports](#) **11**, Article number: 2818 (2021) | [Cite this article](#)

34k Accesses | **89** Altmetric | [Metrics](#)

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- **Restricted accessibility** (varies by API type)

Documentation

[Getting started](#)[Fundamentals ▾](#)[Tools and libraries](#)[Tutorials](#)[API reference index](#)

X API ▴

[Getting started ▾](#)[Tools and libraries ▾](#)[What to build](#)[Migrate ▾](#)[X API v2 ▾](#)[Enterprise - Gnip 2.0 ▾](#)

- Access to Ads API
- \$200 per month
- \$175 per month with annual subscription (\$2,100 total)
- 2 Top-ups allowed

Pro

For startups scaling their business

- Rate-limited access to suite of v2 endpoints, including search and filtered stream
- 1,000,000 Posts per month - GET at the app level
- 300,000 Posts per month - posting limit at the app level
- 1 Project
- 3 Apps per Project with unique Environment (Development/ Production/ Staging)
- Login with X
- Access to Ads API
- \$5,000 per month
- \$4,500 per month with annual subscription (\$54,000 total)
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POLITICAL COMMUNICATION
2025, VOL. 42, NO. 1, 127–150
<https://doi.org/10.1080/10584609.2024.2364072>



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The Effects of COVID-19 Infection on Opposition to COVID-19 Policies: Evidence from the U.S. Congress

Zachary P. Dickson ^a and Tevfik Murat Yildirim ^b

^aDepartment of Methodology, London School of Economics and Political Science, London, UK; ^bDepartment of Media and Social Sciences, University of Stavanger, Stavanger, Norway

ABSTRACT

Elites' skepticism of scientific consensus presents a formidable challenge in addressing critical issues like climate change and global pandemics. While extensive research has explored the capacity of events related to these challenges to act as "exogenous shocks," motivating the general public to reassess their risk perceptions, our understanding of how elites similarly respond to such shocks remains limited. In this article, we investigate whether COVID-19 infections influenced US lawmakers' support for COVID-19 containment measures, focusing on expressed opposition to COVID-19 policies on social media and in press releases throughout the first two years of the pandemic. Employing a staggered difference-in-differences design and matrix completion methods, our analysis reveals that COVID-19 infections caused a reduction of approximately 30% in legislators' expressions of opposition to COVID-19 policies on social media. These findings underscore that elites are indeed responsive to policy shocks – even in highly polarized contexts – when they are personally affected by an issue.

KEYWORDS

COVID-19; polarization; partisanship; political communication; political behavior

- Do US congress members change their positions on COVID-19 after being infected?

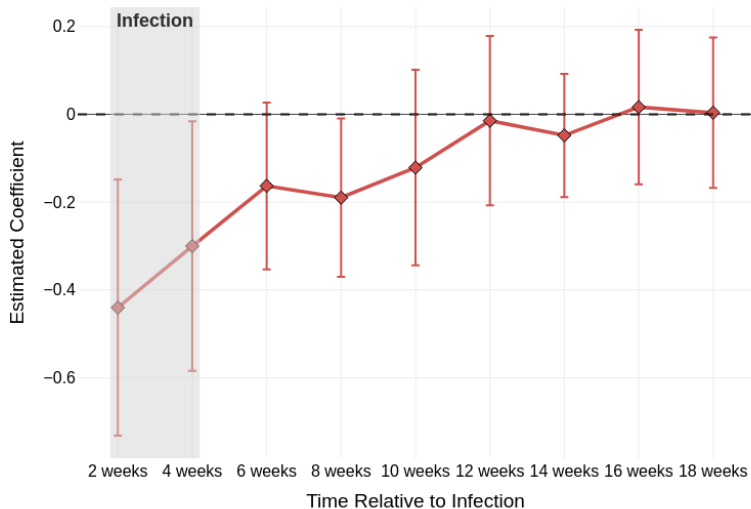
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- Found that being infected with COVID-19 **reduced** the likelihood of opposing COVID-19 policies on Twitter (but only for a bit)

Dickson and Yildirim (2024)



Matrix Completion Estimates and 95% confidence intervals

Polit Behav (2017) 39:629–649
DOI 10.1007/s11109-016-9373-5



ORIGINAL PAPER

Tweetment Effects on the Tweeted: Experimentally Reducing Racist Harassment

Kevin Munger¹

Published online: 11 November 2016
© Springer Science+Business Media New York 2016

Abstract I conduct an experiment which examines the impact of group norm promotion and social sanctioning on racist online harassment. Racist online harassment de-mobilizes the minorities it targets, and the open, unopposed expression of racism in a public forum can legitimize racist viewpoints and prime ethnocentrism. I employ an intervention designed to reduce the use of anti-black racist slurs by white men on Twitter. I collect a sample of Twitter users who have harassed other users and use accounts I control (“bots”) to sanction the harassers. By varying the identity of the bots between in-group (white man) and out-group (black man) and by varying the number of Twitter followers each bot has, I find that subjects who were sanctioned by a high-follower white male significantly reduced their use of a racist slur. This paper extends findings from lab experiments to a naturalistic setting using an objective, behavioral outcome measure and a continuous 2-month data collection period. This represents an advance in the study of prejudiced behavior.

Keywords Online harassment · Social media · Randomized field experiment · Social identity

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Infrastructure

Electrical Distribution Grid Maps

This predictive model can map medium-voltage electrical distribution infrastructure in any country.

[→ Learn More](#)

Inclusive Internet Index

The Inclusive Internet Index measures whether the internet is accessible and affordable, and how it affects social and economic mobility.

[→ Learn More](#)

Commuting Zones

Commuting Zones are geographic areas where people live and work and are useful for understanding local economies, as well as how they differ from traditional boundaries.

[→ Learn More](#)

Infrastructure Route Study

This Infrastructure Route Study contains a collection of open source data collected for expanding fiber routes to extend Internet connectivity in the Democratic Republic of the Congo.

[→ Learn More](#)

Global Urban Areas

The Global Urban Areas dataset is a high resolution dataset consists of 37,000 polygonal areas around the globe, and provides enough detail for most use-cases.

[→ Learn More](#)

Network Coverage Maps

Network Coverage Maps show where people on Facebook have cellular connectivity.

[→ Learn More](#)

Base

The Base Dataset is a foundational element of navigation, local search, and many other location-based applications.

[→ Learn More](#)

Buildings

An alpha version of open map data showcasing over 6 million buildings that have been derived from the US Geological Survey (USGS) 3D Elevation Program Light Detection and Ranging and open building footprint data.

[→ Learn More](#)

Divisions

The Overture Maps Foundation (OMF) divisions dataset provides information on official and non-official organizations of people at the country, region, province, city, and neighborhood level.

[→ Learn More](#)

American Political Science Review (2024) 1–17

doi:10.1017/S0003055424000741 © The Author(s), 2024. Published by Cambridge University Press on behalf of American Political Science Association. This is an Open Access article, distributed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution licence (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0>), which permits unrestricted re-use, distribution and reproduction, provided the original article is properly cited.

Elite Cues and Noncompliance

ZACHARY P. DICKSON *London School of Economics, United Kingdom*

SARA B. HOBOLT *London School of Economics, United Kingdom*

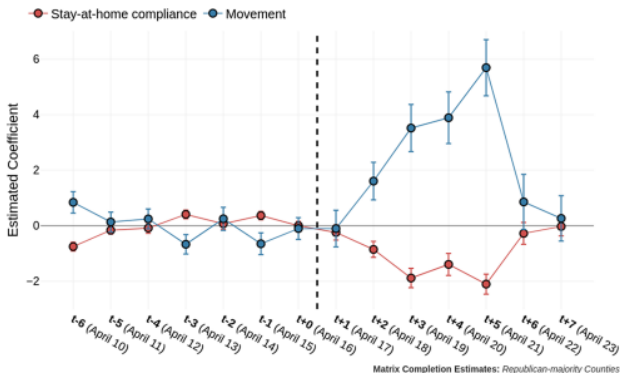
Political leaders increasingly use social media to speak directly to voters, but the extent to which elite cues shape offline political behavior remains unclear. In this article, we study the effects of elite cues on noncompliant behavior, focusing on a series of controversial tweets sent by US President Donald Trump calling for the “liberation” of Minnesota, Virginia, and Michigan from state and local government COVID-19 restrictions. Leveraging the fact that Trump’s messages exclusively referred to three specific US states, we adopt a generalized difference-in-differences design relying on spatial variation to identify the causal effects of the targeted cues. Our analysis shows that the President’s messages led to an increase in movement, a decrease in adherence to stay-at-home restrictions, and an increase in arrests of white Americans for crimes related to civil disobedience and rebellion. These findings demonstrate the consequences of elite cues in polarized environments.

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- **Results:** Trump's messages decreased compliance with COVID restrictions in areas where he was popular

FIGURE 5. Dynamic Effects of “Liberate” Cues on Mobility in Republican Counties



Note: Matrix completion coefficient estimates and 95% confidence intervals for the effect of the cues on movement (blue) and stay-at-home compliance (red) in Republican-majority counties (e.g., model 3 in Tables 1 and 2). The counterfactual includes Republican-majority counties around the country that were not targeted in the President calls for liberation and were under the same mandatory state restrictions.

Facebook Research Example:



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HOME > SCIENCE > VOL. 381, NO. 6656 > HOW DO SOCIAL MEDIA FEED ALGORITHMS AFFECT ATTITUDES AND BEHAVIOR IN AN ELECTION CAMPAIGN?

 | SPECIAL ISSUE RESEARCH ARTICLE | SOCIAL MEDIA



How do social media feed algorithms affect attitudes and behavior in an election campaign?

ANDREW M. GUESS , NEIL MALHOTRA , JENNIFER PAN , PABLO BARBERÁ , HUNT ALLCOTT, TAYLOR BROWN , ADRIANA CRESPO-TENORIO, DREW DIMMERY 
, DEEN FREELON , MATTHEW GENTZKOW , SANDRA GONZÁLEZ-BAILÓN , EDWARD KENNEDY , YOUNG MIE KIM , DAVID LAZER , DEVRA MOEHLER 
, BRENDAN NYHAN , CARLOS VELASCO RIVERA, JAIME SETTLE , DANIEL ROBERT THOMAS, EMILY THORSON , REBEKAH TROMBLE , ARJUN WILKINS, MAGDALENA WOJCIESZAK , BEIXIAN XIONG, CHAD KIEWIT DE JONGE, ANNIE FRANCO, WINTER MASON , NATALIE JOMINI STROUD , AND JOSHUA A. TUCKER 

fewer

[Authors Info & Affiliations](#)

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 35,225  103



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- **Results**: Altering the new feed algo did **not** significantly alter levels of issue polarization, affective polarization, and political knowledge (with some exceptions)

Images, Politicians, and Social Media: Patterns and Effects of Politicians' Image-Based Political Communication Strategies on Social Media

The International Journal of Press/Politics
2021, Vol. 26(1) 119–142
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DOI: 10.1177/1940161220959553
journals.sagepub.com/home/hj



Xénia Farkas¹  and Márton Bene² 

Abstract

Although images have always been part of politics, research on the visual aspects of political communication recently gained momentum, especially with the spread of social media-based political communication. However, there are still several significant research gaps in this field. The aim of this article is to identify and compare the patterns and effects of Hungarian politicians' ($n = 51$) image-based communication on Facebook ($n = 2,992$) and Instagram ($n = 868$) during the Hungarian parliamentary election campaign in 2018. By doing so, we shed light on two important dimensions of personalization: individualization and privatization. This work is designed to fill three gaps in the literature. We argue that existing research of visual political communication (1) treats images predominantly as illustrations, (2) is limited to single-platform studies, and (3) does not investigate the engagement effects of images. To move beyond these limitations, this study investigates images as objects of interest on their own; it adopts a cross-platform comparative approach and examines the engagement effects of visual cues by applying a combination of inductive and deductive qualitative content analysis. Our results show that images are often used to personalize communication. While on Facebook the individualization dimension of personalization is more common and popular, on Instagram its privatization dimension prevails. Furthermore, on Facebook, users like more politics-related candidate-centered images, but on Instagram we could not find similar effects for more informal visuals.

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- Some API access for researchers in the US and Europe

TikTok Research Example

Fifteen Seconds of Fame: TikTok and the Supply Side of Social Video

Benjamin Guinaudeau
University of Konstanz

Kevin Munger
Pennsylvania State University

Fabio Votta
University of Amsterdam

Abstract

TikTok has rapidly developed from a punchline for jokes about “kids these days” into a formidable force in American politics. The speed of this development is unprecedented, even in the rapidly-changing world of digital politics. Through a combination of hashtag and snowball sampling, we identify 11,546 TikTok accounts who primarily post about politics, allowing us to analyze trends in the posting, viewing and commenting behavior on 1,998,642 tiktoks they have uploaded. We test a number of theories about how the unique combination of affordances on TikTok shapes how it is used for political communication. Compared to the dominant platform for political videos (YouTube) we find that a higher percentage of TikTok users upload videos, TikTok view counts are more dominated by virality, and viewership of videos are less dependent on a given accounts’ number of followers/subscribers. We discuss how these findings affect the production of content that ultimately determines the experience of TikTok consumers.

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- Benefits & Limitations of Social Media Data

2 Types of Social Media Data and APIs

- Reddit
- Twitter/X
- Facebook & Instagram
- TikTok

3 Summary

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